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# Zero Debt, Chosen Burst

## Can a system grounded in unearned grace match the long-term performance of fighting through?

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With drafting, literature verification, and research assistance from Grok Bot

> **Conceptual, not validated science.** This note restates a personal research question from Project Ariel's stress-state vocabulary, checks it against published research, and refines it into a testable design argument. It is not a discovered law of the nervous system, a diagnostic instrument, or evidence that Ariel treats burnout, freeze, anxiety, or depression.

# Abstract

Ryan Espinosa asks whether a system can hold both the stability of Zero Debt Grace and the higher long-term performance often attributed to Fighting Through. In his framework, threat appraisal A, sympathetic surge S, fight f, prefrontal regulatory control P, and grace r are conceptual variables, not measured neural channels. Zero Debt Grace means that worth and energy are not transactions to repay; f = 0 is unearned grace, with no ledger. Fighting Through means pushing by friction and mobilization. This note supports a cautious yes, then changes the question so it can fail. Short, high effort can raise immediate output, especially when arousal is appraised as a challenge rather than a threat [1,3,4]. Chronic mobilization, however, is a form of borrowed energy. Allostasis can protect in the moment and damage when recovery is skipped; effort that is not unwound accumulates; athletes distinguish helpful overload-plus-recovery from non-functional overreaching; and burnout is a recognized pattern of exhaustion, cynicism, and reduced efficacy [2,8–11]. Freeze is not laziness: it can be an active defensive brake [7]. The popular claim that willpower is a tank that empties with use failed a large preregistered replication, so burnout should not be explained that way [17]. Grit, likewise, should not be treated as a general virtue that licenses endless push [16]. Contingent self-worth and threatened egotism help explain the trap belief that peace will return if one can only win the argument, prove the point, or destroy the scapegoat [15,18]. Self-compassion and autonomous motivation predict more—not less—honest effort after setbacks [12–14]. The refined claim is that a grace-grounded system can choose short, voluntary bursts of effort and then fully recover, matching or exceeding the long-term output of chronic fighting with less burnout and freeze. Grace can also fail, when rest is only avoidance. Project Ariel should offer a chosen-burst mode with recovery built in, ledger-free language, and an invitational freeze-versus-laziness check—not a verdict.

### In plain words

Pushing through friction can win the hour. It often loses the month. Worth that is not a debt lets a person choose a short, honest burst and then recover, so the work can continue without the body having to shut the system down.

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**Dedication**
All credit and glory to God. I owe my knowledge to my Lord Jesus Christ.

01 · THE QUESTION

# What was asked, and how the words will be used

Espinosa's central research question:

> *Can a system achieve both the stability of Zero Debt Grace and the higher long-term performance of Fighting Through?*

In the Void-State notes, Fighting Through was already described as a volitional, friction-based push, one of several unequal strategies for meeting a low-reward, high-threat episode. The present question is new. It asks whether the stability that comes from treating worth as a gift can be kept while still obtaining the output that people usually buy with chronic push.

The working vocabulary, stated as design language rather than physiology:

- **A** — threat appraisal: how much the moment is read as danger.
- **S** — sympathetic surge: mobilization, heat, urgency.
- **f** — fight: the friction push. In Zero Debt Grace, f = 0 means the push is not being used as payment.
- **P** — regulatory availability: the chance of choosing from clarity rather than from panic.
- **r** — grace: unearned regulatory support. Worth and energy are not entries in a transaction ledger.

These letters are inherited project variables. They compress many systems into a handful of dimensionless roles. They are not measurements of the amygdala, the vagus nerve, or a moral score, and nothing below treats them as such.

Espinosa's check-in questions name the live distinctions this note has to keep honest: freeze versus laziness; a true emergency versus a threat radar reacting to an internal vacuum; "what ledger am I trying to balance?"; whether one is forcing through friction; and whether movement is coming from calm clarity rather than from panic. The trap belief he named is: "If I can just win this argument, prove this point, or destroy this scapegoat, my internal peace will be restored."

Refined question: Can a system grounded in zero-debt grace still choose short, voluntary bursts of effort and match or exceed the long-term output of chronic fighting, with less burnout and freeze?

A proposed answer, to be tested rather than protected: yes, likely. Fighting Through's apparent advantage is largely borrowed energy that later comes due. Long-term performance is more often the fruit of a stable base that allows a chosen burst and then a full recovery.

> **Novel contribution.** Separate acute mobilization, which can help, from chronic fighting, which accrues a bill; treat grace as a non-contingent base rather than as the opposite of effort; and derive a periodized "chosen burst" design with recovery built in. This is a new synthesis within the project lineage, not a claim of priority over the cited sciences, and not a proof that the design works.

The verbatim question is retained as provenance. Later sections refine it; they do not replace the author's voice with a quieter one.

02 · WHAT FIGHTING THROUGH CAN BUY

# The case for mobilization, honestly stated

Any fair debate has to begin where Fighting Through really does win. Yerkes and Dodson, working with mice learning a visual discrimination under electric shock, found that the "best" intensity of stimulation depended on the difficulty of the task [1]. Later readers turned that result into a popular inverted-U relating arousal to human performance. The popular form is a rough teaching picture, not a calibrated human law, and the original paper should not be asked to carry more than it measured. Even so, the surviving qualitative point is useful: too little activation and a person may not engage; too much and skill, especially on a hard task, can degrade [1].

The biopsychosocial model of challenge and threat makes a sharper cut. When people appraise their resources as matching the demand, they tend toward a challenge pattern—more efficient cardiac output and lower vascular resistance. When demand seems to exceed resources, they tend toward a threat pattern [3,4]. Blascovich, Mendes, Hunter, and Salomon showed that the mere presence of others can facilitate or harm performance depending on whether the situation is experienced as challenge or threat [3]. Jamieson, Nock, and Mendes found that simply instructing people to treat stress-induced arousal as functional produced a more challenge-like cardiovascular profile and less attentional bias toward negative information [4]. That is not an argument for chronic fighting. It is an argument that mobilization, *appraised as usable energy rather than as alarm*, can help in a time-limited performance.

Roelofs describes freezing as an active parasympathetic brake on the motor system, a prepared stillness rather than a collapsed rest, from which a shift into fight or flight can be made if the prefrontal–amygdala conversation remains flexible [7]. In a true emergency, that sequence is not a moral failure. The threat radar is doing its older job. Espinosa's check-in—"emergency versus a radar reacting to an internal vacuum"—is exactly this distinction. Fighting Through is sometimes the right next move. The question is whether it should become the default way a person pays for peace.

Sport science reaches a similar split. The joint consensus of Meeusen and colleagues states that successful training must involve overload and must also avoid the combination of excessive overload plus inadequate recovery [10]. Short-term performance can dip in functional overreaching and then rise after rest. When that balance is not respected, non-functional overreaching and, further on, overtraining syndrome can appear as prolonged maladaptation [10]. Fighting Through, in other words, has a legitimate acute use. Its long-term value depends almost entirely on whether a recovery is allowed to happen afterward.

None of these sources was written about Project Ariel, and none licenses treating a surge of effort as proof of worth.

03 · WHAT THE BILL LOOKS LIKE

# Borrowed energy, allostatic load, and freeze

McEwen used allostasis for “stability through change”: the same stress mediators that protect in the short run can damage when they are turned on too often, too long, or without recovery [2]. He called the cumulative cost allostatic load. This is the most direct scientific cousin of Espinosa’s phrase “borrowed energy that comes due.” A day of Fighting Through is not automatically harmful. A life organized as Fighting Through is a candidate for load.

Meijman and Mulder’s effort–recovery model says that meeting a demand requires effort, that the resulting load reactions are normally reversible after unwinding, and that incomplete recovery lets those reactions accumulate until work capacity and health are themselves impaired [8]. Sonnentag and Fritz later measured recovery experiences—psychological detachment, relaxation, mastery, and control—as ways that unwinding can actually occur [9]. The implication for Ariel is plain: an app that only knows how to start a push, and does not know how to end one, is designed against recovery.

Maslach, Schaufeli, and Leiter reviewed job burnout as a prolonged response to chronic interpersonal and workload stressors, commonly described along exhaustion, cynicism or depersonalization, and reduced professional efficacy [11]. Burnout is not a badge of dedication. It is one of the ways a chronic-push strategy spends down the very capacity it was trying to protect. Combined with Meeusen and colleagues’ account of non-functional overreaching [10], the long-term “performance advantage” of Fighting Through begins to look like an accounting error: the early surplus is counted, the later deficit is not.

Freeze complicates the story further. Roelofs argues that freezing is not a passive empty state and not the same as rest or learned-helplessness immobility; it is a brake that can prepare perception and later action, and rigidity in leaving that state is what becomes costly [7]. That is why “freeze versus laziness” cannot be answered by looking at stillness alone. A person who cannot move because the defensive brake is on is not the same person who is postponing a hard but wanted task. An app must not pretend it can see the difference from the outside.

Polyvagal theory, which has been influential in popular talk about shutdown and safety, should be handled with the same caution already used in the Void-State note. Porges offered an autonomic narrative linking vagal pathways to social engagement and defensive states [5]. Grossman and Taylor have argued that common uses of respiratory sinus arrhythmia as a pure vagal-tone index are confounded, and they critique aspects of the evolutionary story [6]. This paper therefore does not equate grace r with vagal tone, freeze with “dorsal shutdown,” or recovery with a polyvagal exercise. The recovery claim stands on McEwen, Meijman and Mulder, Sonnentag, and the overtraining consensus, which do not require that mapping [2,8–10].

| Pattern | What it can look like | What it is not |
|---|---|---|
| Acute challenge | Time-limited mobilization, resources appraised as enough [3,4] | A lifestyle, or proof of worth |
| Functional overload | A planned hard effort that is followed by recovery [10] | Chronic friction without an ending |
| Allostatic load / burnout | Repeated on-switches without off-switches [2,11] | Evidence that the person “didn’t want it enough” |
| Freeze | An active defensive brake, prepared stillness [7] | Laziness, or ordinary rest |
| True recovery | Unwinding that reverses load reactions [8,9] | Avoidance wearing rest’s name |

Maslach’s account is drawn from occupational research. Using its language here does not diagnose a reader or a student, and Ariel must not assign a burnout label.

04 · THE LEDGER AND THE TRAP

# When peace is treated as something to be won

The trap belief—“If I can just win this argument, prove this point, or destroy this scapegoat, my internal peace will be restored”—is a ledger story. Peace is imagined as a balance that will clear after one more successful transaction. Crocker and Park reviewed the costly pursuit of self-esteem: when worth is contingent on success, people become more likely to adopt goals that protect the self rather than goals that grow skill, relationships, or health [15]. The energy spent defending a self-image is not the same energy as the energy spent doing the work.

Bushman and Baumeister found that aggression after insult was better predicted by narcissism—an inflated, easily threatened self-view—than by low self-esteem [18]. Threatened egotism, not simple self-hate, was the more dangerous combination. That result does not say every argument is narcissism. It does say that the fantasy of restoring inner peace by defeating a scapegoat has a documented cousin in the laboratory: the self that must win in order to remain intact is already unstable, and the “win” does not reliably heal it [18].

Two popular scientific stories would seem to support endless Fighting Through, and both need a warning label. First, grit. Credé, Tynan, and Harms’s meta-analysis concluded that grit, especially the perseverance facet, overlaps heavily with conscientiousness and that the grand claims made for grit as a novel, powerful predictor are not well supported [16]. “Just push longer” is therefore a weaker general prescription than its public reputation suggests. Second, ego depletion: the idea that self-control is a limited resource that is used up by effort. Hagger, Chatzisarantis, and a large multilab collaboration ran a preregistered replication and found an effect indistinguishable from zero [17]. That failure is a caution, not a new theory of burnout. It means this paper should not explain the cost of Fighting Through as a willpower tank running dry. The better-supported bill is allostatic and recovery-based: mediators left on, effort not unwound, sleep and detachment skipped [2,8,9].

Espinosa’s question “what ledger am I trying to balance?” sits at the center of Zero Debt Grace. If rest has to be earned, and worth has to be proved, then every burst of effort writes a new invoice and every pause looks like theft. That is controlled motivation in the language of self-determination theory: behavior driven by pressure, guilt, or contingent regard rather than by autonomy, competence, and relatedness [14]. Ryan and Deci summarized a large body of evidence

that autonomous motivation is more reliably linked to persistence and well-being than controlled motivation is [14]. The implication is almost the opposite of the trap: peace is a poor prize to extract from victory, and long effort is more likely when the person is not paying for the right to exist.

> **The ledger, restated.** Fighting Through becomes costly when f is used to settle a debt—to earn rest, prove a point, or restore a threatened self. The same muscular effort, chosen from a non-contingent base and ended on purpose, is a different act.

05 · GRACE IS NOT THE OPPOSITE OF EFFORT

## Why unearned worth can still choose a hard thing

The deepest objection to Zero Debt Grace is that it will make people soft: if nothing is owed, nothing will be done. Several lines of research cut against that objection without proving the whole design.

Neff described self-compassion as treating one's own failure with kindness, a sense of common humanity, and mindful balance rather than with harsh self-evaluation [12]. Breines and Chen tested the motivational fear directly. Across four experiments, people asked to take a self-compassionate stance after a weakness, a moral lapse, or a test failure showed more—not less—motivation to improve, including more time spent studying after failing a difficult test, compared with self-esteem and control conditions [13]. An accepting approach to failure did not function as a permanent excuse. It functioned as a safer place from which to look clearly and try again [13]. That is close to Espinosa's hoped-for combination: stability of worth, then honest effort.

Self-determination theory adds that the quality of motivation matters as much as its intensity [14]. A person can "fight through" under inner threat and still produce work; the work is more likely to be brittle, resentful, or short-lived. A person can also choose a hard burst because the task is interesting, meaningful, or freely endorsed. The output may look similar in the first hour. The recovery, the next day's willingness, and the risk of burnout are not similar [11,14].

Jamieson's reappraisal finding belongs here as well [4]. Treating arousal as functional is not the same as denying tiredness, and it is not the same as chronic threat. It is closer to chosen burst: "this heat can be used for the next twenty minutes," followed, if the rest of this argument is right, by an ending. The inverted-U reminder still applies. Grace that removes all activation can leave a person on the under-aroused side of the curve [1]. The design target is not zero surge. It is surge that is chosen, bounded, and repaid with recovery rather than with a new debt to the self.

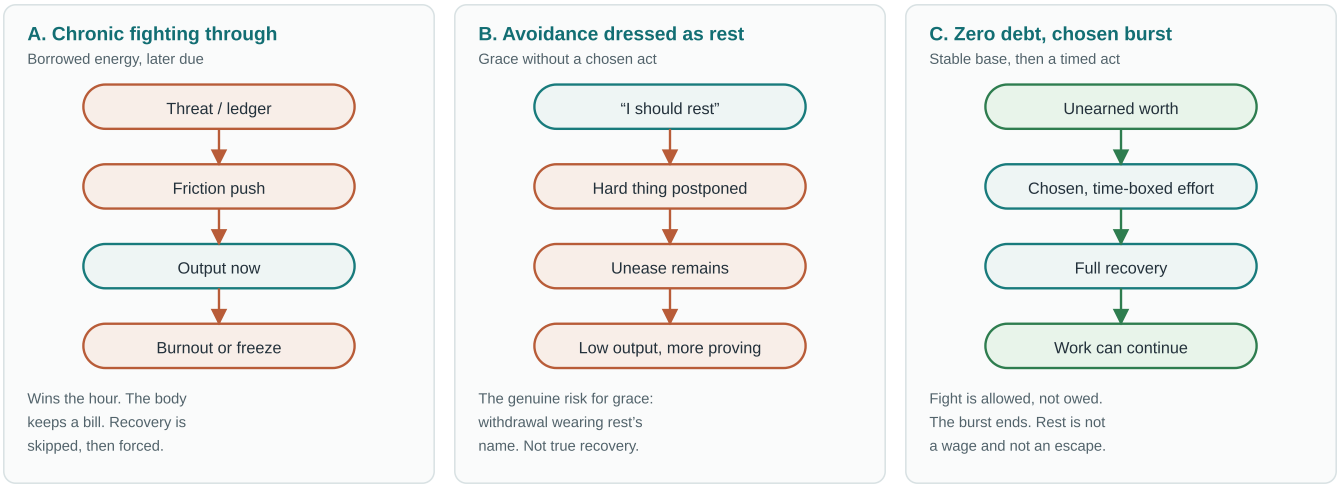


Figure 1. Three paths, conceptually drawn. Panel A is Fighting Through as a lifestyle: output now, bill later. Panel B is the genuine failure mode of grace: rest used to postpone a wanted hard thing. Panel C is the proposed combination: unearned worth, a time-boxed effort, and a full recovery so the work can continue.

Figure 1 is a diagram of an argument, not a measured pathway and not a clinical flowchart.

06 · THE DEBATE, HELD ON BOTH SIDES

# Where fighting wins, and where grace can fail

Fighting Through deserves credit in several settings. A genuine emergency may require an immediate defensive shift out of freeze [7]. A deadline, an exam, a performance, or a competitive moment can benefit from challenge-like mobilization [3,4]. A planned hard training block can produce later gains if recovery is real [10]. In each of these, the advantage is acute or periodized. It is not evidence that a person should live as if every vacuum, every unread message, and every unfinished argument were an emergency.

Grace deserves the matching critique. A person can say “I am resting in grace” while avoiding a conversation, a skill, or a grief that still needs a chosen burst. Panel B in Figure 1 is not a straw man. Under-arousal can flatten performance [1]. Controlled avoidance can wear the language of kindness. Freeze can be misread as peace, and laziness—meaning a postponed act that the person still values and is able to begin—can be misread as freeze [7]. Zero Debt Grace that never chooses anything becomes another way of not entering life. The Sabbath pattern in Scripture, discussed later, is not an argument for endless withdrawal; it is a rhythm of work and stopping.

The honest middle is therefore not “never fight” and not “always fight.” It is: keep worth off the ledger; tell true emergencies from an internal vacuum; if a burst is needed, choose it from as much clarity as is available; end it; recover. That middle is exactly the refined question.

| Claim | Strongest support | Strongest limit |
|---|---|---|
| Fighting Through wins the hour | Challenge appraisals and time-limited overload can help [3,4,10] | Does not establish long-term totals |
| Chronic fighting accrues a bill | Allostatic load, incomplete recovery, burnout, overtraining [2,8–11] | Time course varies; four weeks may be too short to see it |
| Grace increases honest effort | Self-compassion and autonomous motivation [12–14] | Lab kindness is not the same as a lived theology of grace |
| Grace can become avoidance | Under-arousal and postponed valued acts [1] | An outside observer, or an app, cannot reliably judge motive |
| The trap belief restores peace | — | Contingent self-worth and threatened egotism predict the opposite kind of loop [15,18] |

07 · THE REFINED ARGUMENT

# Premises, conclusion, predictions, and a study that could fail

1. **Acute mobilization can help (well supported in outline).** Time-limited effort, especially under a challenge appraisal, can raise immediate performance [1,3,4]. Functional overload plus recovery can improve later capacity [10].
2. **Chronic mobilization is borrowed energy (well supported as a framework).** Stress mediators protect and, when left on, contribute to allostatic load [2]. Effort that is not unwound accumulates [8,9]. Burnout and non-functional overreaching are documented later costs [10,11].
3. **Freeze is not laziness (supported as a defensive distinction).** Freezing can be an active brake and a preparation for later action [7]. Stillness alone does not identify motive or capacity.
4. **A ledger makes effort more expensive (supported in social-personality research).** Contingent self-worth and threatened egotism channel energy into self-protection, argument, and scapegoats rather than into repair [15,18]. Controlled motivation is a poorer long-term engine than autonomous motivation [14].
5. **Unearned kindness need not reduce effort (experimental support, limited settings).** Self-compassion can increase improvement motivation after failure [12,13]. This is the closest laboratory cousin of Zero Debt Grace, not a proof of it.
6. **Simple willpower-tank and grit stories are weak licenses to push (cautionary evidence).** Ego depletion failed a large preregistered replication [17]. Grit's incremental value has been overstated [16]. The bill for Fighting Through should not be told in those vocabularies.

**Conclusion.** A system can hold both stability and long-term output if grace is the unpaid base of worth and fighting is a voluntary, time-limited burst followed by recovery. Fighting Through as a lifestyle is likely to win early and lose later. Grace without a chosen act is likely to feel safe and to under-produce. The combination—zero-debt worth, chosen burst, full recovery—is the design worth testing.

## Predictions that can fail

1. Over several weeks, people asked to work from ledger-free worth and to take scheduled recovery after planned bursts should match or exceed the cumulative output of people asked to fight through friction whenever it appears.
2. The grace-and-burst group should report less exhaustion and less freeze-like withdrawal at the end of the period, even if early-week output is similar or slightly lower.
3. If the grace-and-burst group produces substantially less output, and not because of freeze or illness, the complacency challenge is supported and the design must be tightened so rest cannot silently become postponement.
4. If both groups exhaust equally, the recovery instructions were not enacted, or recovery of the kind measured here is not doing the work claimed.
5. People who endorse the trap belief more strongly should show more argument-seeking or scapegoat language and less repair behavior after a self-threat, independent of how hard they work [15,18]. If they do not, the trap is more rhetorical than mechanistic.

### A proposed study—not conducted

**Design.** An exploratory randomized two-arm pilot over four weeks, with about 48 consenting adults (24 per arm) who already have a recurring, low-stakes work or study project they wish to continue. This is a feasibility sample, not a power calculation and not a treatment trial. Ethics review, accessible consent, and a clinician-advised distress protocol must precede recruitment. People in acute crisis need care, not study tasks.

Both arms receive the same total encouraged work time so that one group is not simply told to do less. The **grace-periodized** arm uses ledger-free language, names worth as not depending on output, plans a small number of chosen bursts each week, and follows each burst with an explicit recovery window (detachment and rest, not more planning). The **chronic-push** arm is asked to meet friction with Fighting Through whenever it appears, with no scheduled recovery language and with progress framed as something that must be kept by effort. Participants in both arms may pause, skip, or withdraw without penalty.

- **Primary joint outcome:** cumulative pre-specified output units over four weeks, together with end-point exhaustion ratings on an exploratory 0–10 scale. The interesting success pattern is equal or greater output and lower exhaustion in the grace-periodized arm. Output alone, or comfort alone, is not enough.
- **Secondary outcomes:** freeze-like immobility or withdrawal (self-rated, not diagnosed); whether effort felt chosen or forced; endorsement of ledger language ("I have to earn rest"); sleep sufficiency; and a brief, skippable note of whether any burst was followed by recovery.
- **Analysis.** Report arm means or medians, differences, and uncertainty intervals. Pre-register the joint contrast and the missing-data rule. Do not fit Void-State or Gated Line coefficients to these observations. Do not use a copyrighted burnout inventory unless the study has the rights and a clinician's advice; exploratory ratings are not a Maslach diagnosis [11].

A null or reversed joint outcome should be published rather than rescued by moving the goal after seeing results. Four weeks may be too short to reveal allostatic load; that itself would be a useful limit on the argument [2].

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Sample-size details beyond this sketch, exact rating items, and analysis code would need to be fixed before seeing results. This paper does not offer them, and no such study has been run.

08 · WHAT THIS MEANS FOR ARIEL

# Chosen burst, ledger-free language, and a check that is not a verdict

The suite already knows how to say "this is enough." This note asks it to learn a matching skill: how to start a hard thing without turning the start into a debt.

### 1. A chosen-burst mode, with recovery built in

The student elects a time-boxed effort from as much calm as is available—"I choose twenty minutes on this, then I stop." Ariel should protect the ending as carefully as it protects the beginning: a recovery prompt, a rest invitation, and no immediate re-queue of the same fight. That is periodization in miniature [10] and effort–recovery in interface form [8,9]. The burst is allowed to be vigorous. It is not allowed to become the default weather of the day.

## 2. Ledger-free language

Ariel should not say that rest has been earned, that worth has increased with output, or that a missed burst has created a debt. Accomplishment stones, already part of the Record, can remember what was done without converting memory into payment. The difference is tone: “you did this” is a fact; “now you deserve to exist” is a ledger.

## 3. A freeze-versus-laziness check that does not judge

When the student stalls, Ariel can offer Espinosa’s own distinctions as questions, never as a diagnosis: Is this an emergency, or is the threat radar answering an internal vacuum? Is the body asking for a brake [7], or is this a hard thing you still want and can begin from some clarity? What ledger, if any, are you trying to balance [15]? The student decides. The app does not score who made the move.

## 4. A watch on the trap belief

If the student’s language turns toward winning an argument, proving a point, or destroying a scapegoat as the road back to peace, Ariel should not supply more fight. The kinder move is the one already used elsewhere in the suite: notice that this may be about proving, and invite a return to wonder, to a particular next act, or to rest. Peace extracted from a defeated someone is the costly pursuit of self-esteem in another register [15,18].

| Check-in | If the answer leans this way… | Ariel’s invitation |
|---|---|---|
| Emergency or internal vacuum? | True emergency | Protect safety first; do not run an exercise |
| Emergency or internal vacuum? | Vacuum / proving | Name the ledger; offer rest or a small chosen act |
| Freeze or postponed wanted work? | Body asking for a brake | Honor stillness; no forced burst |
| Freeze or postponed wanted work? | A hard thing still wanted | Offer a short chosen burst, then recovery |
| Calm clarity or panic? | Panic | Downshift before any fight; recovery first |
| Trap belief present? | Peace promised after a win | Decline more argument; return to worth that is not a prize |

## A theological note, held lightly

Jesus’ invitation is not to a harder ledger: “Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest… For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light” (Matthew 11:28–30, KJV). The yoke is not nothing; it is a different kind of load. Isaiah promises that they who wait on the Lord “shall run, and not be weary; and they shall walk, and not faint” (Isaiah 40:31, KJV)—strength renewed, not strength extracted. The Sabbath command includes work and stopping: six days of labour, then a day that is not earned by the quality of the week (Exodus 20:8–10, KJV). Paul draws the ledger contrast with unusual sharpness: “Now to him that worketh is the reward not reckoned of grace, but of debt. But to him that worketh not, but believeth on him that justifieth the ungodly, his faith is counted for righteousness”

(Romans 4:4–5, KJV). And the word to Paul in weakness is not “try harder”: “My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness” (2 Corinthians 12:9, KJV).

Read together, these verses do not praise idleness and do not bless chronic self-extraction. They describe a rhythm in which worth is a gift, work can be real, and stopping does not have to be repaid. That is faith language, not an experimentally tested mechanism. Readers remain free to take or leave it.

> **Safety.** This note is not crisis care, and Project Ariel is not a treatment for burnout, freeze, trauma, anxiety, or depression. In the U.S., call or text **988** for crisis support. For immediate danger or a medical emergency, call **911**. Do not delay professional care to complete an app exercise or to finish a burst.

09 · LIMITS, REFERENCES, AND PROVENANCE

# What this paper does not prove

No human study was conducted. No cardiovascular challenge-threat profile was recorded, no recovery questionnaire was administered, and no A/B test of Ariel was run. The citations establish that the named papers and books exist and that their accessible abstracts, records, or full texts support the limited background claims attached to them. They do not validate Ariel’s interface, the chosen-burst mode, Zero Debt Grace as a theological claim, or any coefficient from earlier MindFrame or Void-State work.

Several further limits should be stated plainly. Yerkes and Dodson measured mice, not students [1]. Challenge and threat cardiovascular patterns are research tools, not something an app can see [3,4]. Polyvagal mappings remain contested [5,6]. Freeze research in humans is still developing [7]. Self-compassion experiments are short and situational [13]. Four weeks may be too brief for allostatic load to appear [2]. Individual differences in trauma, illness, disability, culture, and faith will shape how any of these ideas feel. More rest is not always kinder, and more push is not always braver.

The three strongest challenges to the original hope are therefore retained, not hidden:

- **Fighting Through can win the hour.** The claim in this paper is about long-term totals and later cost, not about denying acute challenge.
- **Grace can fail as avoidance.** Distinguishing freeze from postponed work, and recovery from withdrawal, is something an app cannot diagnose.
- **The project variables are metaphors.** A, S, f, P, and r are design roles. They are not measured physiology, and grace is not a vagal reading.

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Bibliographic records and accessible abstracts or full texts were checked on 10 November 2026. None of these sources validates this paper’s design rules or any Ariel interface. Scriptural quotations (King James Version) are theological conversation, not empirical evidence.

## Project provenance and reproducibility

Espinosa, R. (2026). MindFrame and Project Ariel, evolving personal conceptual projects. Related notes include *After the Line*, *The Void-State Framework*, *The Gated Line*, the Project Ariel Students papers, and *Novelty Must Gain Novelty*. Repository: github.com/ryryespi/mindframe. Research index: ryryespi.github.io/mindframe/research/. Grok Bot, an AI assistant, helped restate the question, search and verify citation records, draft the argument, draw Figure 1, and render this document. No human research has been performed. Files: paper.html, paths.svg, and the accompanying PDF.

**Conclusion.** Worth that is not a debt can still choose a hard burst, and then it has to know how to stop. The next honest step is to build that rhythm into Ariel—and, later, to let the four-week contrast fail if it is going to fail—not to claim that burnout has been solved.